



SLIDE 1 - GREEN BELT, NOT GREY BELT

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Hello, and thank you everyone for coming tonight.

If you don't know me, I'm Graham, and I'm just one of the cogs in the mechanism that has made Wyburns Area Residents what it has become so far.

But before I go any further, I really must say thank you to the rest of that mechanism — the people behind Wyburns Area Residents who have helped get us to this point.

They've been doing the research, dealing with the administration, designing the leaflets, printing them, delivering them, working on the website, gathering information and helping organise everything you've seen today.

None of this has happened because of one person. It has been a real group effort, and I want to give them a massive thank you for all the time and work they have put in.

Over the last few months, we've been doing a lot of research and investigation into this planning application because there are some very serious concerns about what is being proposed.

Tonight is really about sharing that information with you, keeping everyone up to date with what we have found, and explaining the concerns that have come out of that work. But it is also about hearing from you. We want to know what your concerns are, what your experiences are, and what you think about the proposal.

We're also very fortunate to have a number of councillors with us tonight who have kindly come along to listen, answer questions where they can, and help residents understand what can be done next.

So hopefully, by the end of tonight, everybody will have a much clearer picture of what is being proposed, why there are concerns, and what each of us can do about it.



SLIDE 2 - WHY WE ARE HERE

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Before we start looking at the documents and the research, I just want to make one thing clear.

We're not here because we're against development, and we're not against housing. That's not the case at all. If nobody had ever built houses, and there had never been any development, none of us would be living where we are today.

So that isn't the issue.

The issue is whether this is the right place for this development.

Is it an appropriate place?

Is it genuinely sustainable?

Would it actually work in practice?

And can everything needed to make it work properly really be delivered?

Those are the questions we're looking at tonight.

And after spending all this time going through the documents, doing the research and looking at what is actually being proposed, my own view is very clear.

No. I don't believe it is.

I don't believe this is an appropriate, sustainable or properly deliverable development for this location.



SLIDE 3 - WHERE IS LOWER WYBURNS?

SPEAKER SCRIPT

So, where actually is Lower Wyburns?

We keep hearing people talking about the development, but where is it actually going to be?

Well, it's here — around Lower Wyburns Farm.

Just to help everyone get their bearings, here's the farm, here's Wyburns School, here are the allotments, and this is where Eastwood Brook runs through the area.

We'll come back to the Brook later, because it becomes quite important when we start looking at the Green Belt, flooding and the way the land is divided up.

The site sits right on the edge of Rayleigh, in the Green Belt.

There are two main parts to it — a southern area and a northern area — and together they've been treated as one development site.

So this slide is really just about getting the geography clear before we start looking at the individual issues.



SLIDE 4 - WHAT IS PROPOSED?

SPEAKER SCRIPT

So, what exactly are they proposing here?

The developer is asking for permission to build 94 homes.

Most of the building would be on the southern part of the site. The northern part is mainly shown as open space, recreational space and play areas.

There would also be a new access from Daws Heath Road.

And provision has been made for at least 201 cars.

Keep that number in mind — 201 cars or more for 94 homes — because we're going to come back to it later when we talk about how sustainable this location really is and how people are actually likely to travel day to day.

So, in simple terms: 94 homes, a new access onto Daws Heath Road, and parking provision for at least 201 cars.



SLIDE 5 - WHO IS DOING THIS?

SPEAKER SCRIPT

So, who is actually behind this proposal?

Who are they, what do they do, and what is their connection with Lower Wyburns?

Bellway started as a family business in 1946 and has grown into a national housebuilder.

Their Strategic Land team specialises in finding land, promoting it for development and taking sites through the planning process.

For Lower Wyburns, Bellway Strategic Land is one of the named applicants and is the company bringing forward the proposal for 94 homes.

Then there is Chelgate Local.

Chelgate Local is not the builder. It is a planning communications and public-affairs company that works for developers on consultation, political engagement and community engagement.

Their own website says they “understand the politics of planning”, and their teams include people with direct experience of local government and planning — including current and former councillors and former council planning officers.

Chelgate also promotes its experience of helping development proposals through the planning process. On its own website it gives examples of schemes where earlier proposals had faced refusal or strong opposition, and where Chelgate was later brought in to handle political and community engagement for a new application.

So when we talk about the exhibition, consultation website, helpline and Chelgate email address for Lower Wyburns, it is worth remembering that Chelgate had been appointed by Bellway to carry out that consultation work on the developer’s behalf.

So, in very simple terms:

Bellway is promoting the development.

Chelgate Local is handling the consultation and public-facing engagement for Bellway.

And the application form itself lists Bellway Strategic Land and Sally Stokes as applicants.



SLIDE 6 - TWO ACTIONS TONIGHT

SPEAKER SCRIPT

There are two separate things we'd like residents to do.

First, if you're concerned about the Bellway scheme, make a planning objection to the correct application. We'll run through how to do that properly later on in the meeting.

Second, contact the councillors about the Council's Green Belt assessment of this area.

These are two completely different processes, so doing one does not do the other.

Ideally, we'd like people to do both.

We'll explain each one properly as we go through tonight, so by the end everyone should know what they need to do and where they need to send it.



SLIDE 7 - GREEN BELT ASSESSMENT

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now we come to one of the biggest issues — the Green Belt assessment.

The Council's latest assessment looks at this area as RA50 and RA51. Our concern is that the way the land has been assessed does not properly reflect what is actually there on the ground.

In particular, we believe the role of Eastwood Brook, the existing physical boundaries, and the differences between the various parts of the land have not been properly recognised.

The latest assessment also raises the possibility of this land being treated as grey belt.

We dispute that conclusion.

We have therefore asked the Council to reassess the area before the Local Plan goes any further.

And that is what the next few slides are about — why we believe the Green Belt assessment needs another look.



SLIDE 8 - EASTWOOD BROOK

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Eastwood Brook is important because it is not just a small ditch. The Environment Agency officially classes it as a Main River — that is simply their official term for a river they have a particular role in managing.

Yet the main written reasoning for RA51 does not actually name Eastwood Brook, and RA50 only refers to a “small water course.”

Our question is very simple:

If the Brook forms a real physical edge in the landscape, has that role been properly considered?

On the map, this is where the Brook runs, so you can see why we believe it should have been looked at properly as part of the Green Belt assessment.



SLIDE 9 - FAIR PARCEL DIVISION

SPEAKER SCRIPT

This brings us to another concern: how the land's actually been divided up for assessment.

It was one plot of land that's now been cut into four.

Some of it is open fields, and some of it is smaller areas with buildings, like the farmstead at Lower Wyburns, that could be classed as a developed feature.

Now, when this is assessed, it should be split into areas of like for like, so that one area of development doesn't affect the assessment of an open area.

But unfortunately, this doesn't appear to have been done, giving us results from the assessment which aren't fair or accurate.



SLIDE 10 - USE REAL BOUNDARIES

SPEAKER SCRIPT

And this follows directly on from the last point.

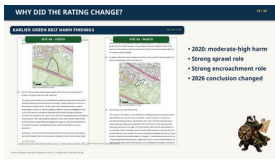
When the land's divided up into various Green Belt assessments, it should be divided using real, recognisable boundaries on the ground wherever possible.

In this area, we already have those boundaries: Eastwood Brook, woodland, established vegetation, roads and the existing edge of the settlement.

These aren't lines someone has simply drawn on a map. They are physical features that actually exist in the landscape.

So our question is: why not use those real boundaries when deciding how the land should be divided and assessed?

If the parcels are drawn differently, that can affect the assessment and the outcome at the end.



SLIDE 11 - WHY DID THE RATING CHANGE?

SPEAKER SCRIPT

This is another question we think needs a proper answer.

Back in 2020, the earlier Green Belt work assessed the release of this land as causing moderate-high harm.

It was considered to have a strong role in preventing sprawl and a strong role in preventing encroachment into the countryside.

But in the latest assessment, the conclusion has changed.

So the obvious question is: what has actually changed on the ground to justify that change in assessment?

The land hasn't suddenly moved. The countryside hasn't disappeared.

If the assessment has changed significantly, we believe residents are entitled to understand why it has changed and what evidence supports that change.



SLIDE 12 - HISTORIC LANDSCAPE

SPEAKER SCRIPT

There's also a historical side to this site which we believe needs to be properly looked at.

We know there is a historic farmstead, now known as Lower Wyburns Farm, together with old field boundaries and historic routeways in this area.

This 1840 tithe map shows the footprint of the farmstead, and that can then be followed through consecutive Ordnance Survey maps right up to the present day.

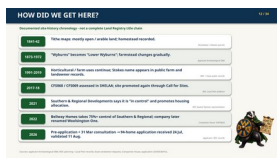
So we believe this deserves proper specialist assessment, rather than simply being dismissed or overlooked.

And our archaeological research is showing that this forms part of an increasingly important historic landscape, which we'll talk about a bit more later on.

Unfortunately, Bellway and Sally Stokes' application proposes the demolition of this historic farmstead.

And although the property may be privately owned, its historic significance isn't just a private matter. It forms part of Rayleigh's long-standing heritage, setting and special character.

That's why we believe its significance should be properly understood before anything is demolished and potentially lost for good.



SLIDE 13 - HOW DID WE GET HERE?

SPEAKER SCRIPT

So how did we actually get from an historic farmstead and open land to the planning application we have in front of us today?

The history of the site can be followed through a series of maps, records and planning documents.

In the 1840s tithe maps, most of the land is shown as open or agricultural, with the homestead already there.

Through later Ordnance Survey mapping, the farmstead continues to appear, and over time the name develops into Lower Wyburns.

In more recent decades, parts of the land were used for farming and horticultural purposes.

By 2017 and 2018, the site had entered the Council's housing-land process through the Call for Sites and SHELAA work.

In 2021, Southern & Regional Developments was promoting the land for housing allocation and stating that it was in control of the site.

In 2022, Bellway Homes took a controlling interest in the company involved.

And by 2026, we had the pre-application process, the public consultation, and then the current application for 94 homes, received in July and validated in August.

So this slide is really showing the documented journey of the site from its historic agricultural setting to the development proposal we are dealing with today.

It's not intended to be a complete Land Registry ownership history, but it does show how the site has gradually moved through the development process.



SLIDE 14 - PREVIOUSLY DEVELOPED LAND?

SPEAKER SCRIPT

This is another area where we think there are some important questions.

In the applicant's Planning Statement, they describe a "significant" amount of the site as previously developed land.

But when you look at their other documents, the picture isn't quite so straightforward.

Their own Flood Risk Assessment describes the southern parcel as predominantly greenfield in character, and their Landscape report describes part of it as three paddocks.

And when you look at the historic aerial photographs, you can see buildings concentrated in certain areas, but large areas of open land remain.

Then look at the northern parcel. What you have there includes polytunnels and areas of loose gravel hardstanding.

Those are very different from permanent buildings and permanently developed land, so we think there is a serious question over how much weight can properly be given to those features when deciding whether this land is previously developed.

So the question we're asking is very simple:

Exactly which parts of this site genuinely qualify as previously developed land?

Because that distinction matters when this site is being assessed for development.



SLIDE 15 - THE SITE THROUGH TIME

SPEAKER SCRIPT

These aerial photographs help show how the site has changed over the last 26 years.

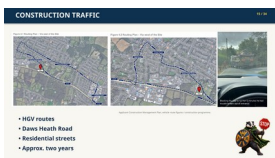
You can see that the farmstead area has grown slightly over that period, but the open land to the east has remained open.

There is no visible sign in these photographs of that eastern land having been developed.

So, on the evidence shown here, it is very difficult to see how that open land could reasonably be described as previously developed land.

These photographs don't show a site that has all been developed and then returned to open land. They show development concentrated around the farmstead, with substantial open land remaining alongside it.

And again, that is why we are questioning the way the applicant describes the site and asking whether some of the claims being made about previously developed land are actually supported by the evidence.



SLIDE 16 - CONSTRUCTION TRAFFIC

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now we come to something that will have a very direct effect on local residents — construction traffic.

The applicant's own Construction Management Plan shows HGVs and other construction vehicles using Daws Heath Road to reach the site. The suggested routes bring construction traffic in from the A127 through the surrounding road network and then along Daws Heath Road.

And this isn't going to be a few weeks of inconvenience. The construction period is expected to last around two years.

So we need to look at what that actually means in practice: HGVs, deliveries and construction vehicles using a narrow rural road alongside the people who already live here and use it every day.

[PAUSE — TALK THROUGH THE MAP AND EXPLAIN THE PROPOSED HGV ROUTES]

Once you look at the route they are proposing,



SLIDE 17 - DAWS HEATH ROAD REALITY

SPEAKER SCRIPT

And this is the reality of Daws Heath Road.

In places, it is only around 4.3 metres wide. It's a narrow rural lane, and there is no continuous footway along it.

Local residents already know what happens when larger vehicles meet other traffic here. Vehicles end up using the verge, and passing can become extremely difficult.

But this road isn't only used by cars.

It is used by pedestrians, children, older residents and people using mobility scooters, as well as the normal day-to-day traffic.

So when we talk about putting construction HGVs along Daws Heath Road, we need to look at the road as it actually is, not simply as a line on a transport plan.

And it isn't just the route in from the east that is going to be affected. Construction traffic is also proposed to come down from the Rayleigh side.

As we all know, there are parked cars along that route, as well as children travelling to and from Wyburns School. Put HGVs into that environment and there are obvious questions about how those vehicles are going to pass safely.

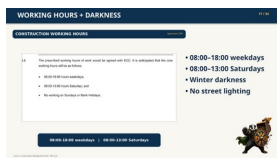
To us, that creates a very serious road-safety concern.

Then there is the construction site itself. Think about the kind of hot, dry summer we've just had. With excavation, earth moving and construction taking place, how are dust and dirt going to be controlled?

And then there is the noise and diesel emissions from diggers, HGVs and other construction machinery, potentially over a construction period of around two years.

These are real effects on the people who already live here, and we don't believe they have been given anything like enough weight.

This feels completely one-sided. The developer gets the development it wants, while the existing community is being asked to accept the disruption and the loss of things that we value.



SLIDE 18 - WORKING HOURS + DARKNESS

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Then we need to look at the proposed construction working hours.

The applicant's Construction Management Plan proposes working from 8 o'clock in the morning until 6 o'clock in the evening, Monday to Friday, and 8 o'clock until 1 o'clock on Saturdays.

Think about what that means during the winter months.

For a significant part of those working hours, it will be dark, and Daws Heath Road itself has no street lighting.

So you potentially have construction vehicles and HGVs travelling along this narrow rural road in darkness, at the same time as residents, pedestrians and other road users.

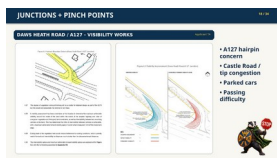
And if anyone here comes from around Daws Heath Road or Castle Road, or uses the tip and knows what traffic conditions can be like around there, they'll understand the problem.

It can already be extremely congested, and at times it can feel almost gridlocked. Now add HGVs carrying muck away from the site and delivery vehicles coming in, because that is one of the routes the construction traffic is proposed to use.

What is that going to be like then?

It's difficult enough now. Put large construction vehicles into that mix and there is a very real risk of making an already congested route significantly worse.

Again, we have to ask whether the practical reality of these roads has really been properly considered.



SLIDE 19 - JUNCTIONS + PINCH POINTS

SPEAKER SCRIPT

And this brings us to the junctions and pinch points along those routes.

We've already talked about the congestion around Castle Road and the tip, but there are other problem areas as well.

At the A127 end of Daws Heath Road, there is a very tight bend and a constrained junction. The applicant's own transport assessment identifies limited visibility there.

Then along the route itself you have parked cars, narrow sections of road and places where two larger vehicles can struggle to pass.

These aren't theoretical problems. They're conditions local people deal with already.

So before anybody says these roads can accommodate construction HGVs for around two years, we think they need to look very carefully at how these vehicles are actually going to get through these pinch points safely and without causing serious disruption.

Again, from a resident's point of view, it feels as though the impact on the people who already live here has been given far too little consideration.

The effect on residents, the roads, the environment and everyday life all seem to come second to making the development work.

And that is what is so frustrating about this proposal.

We are being asked to accept the disruption, the congestion and the risks, while the developer gets the benefit of the development.

To me, that balance is completely wrong, and I find it disgraceful that these very obvious problems can be treated as though they are somehow acceptable.



SLIDE 20 - PERMANENT TRAFFIC

SPEAKER SCRIPT

And of course, the traffic problem doesn't disappear when the construction finishes.

This development is for 94 homes, with provision for 201 parking spaces.

That tells us something important. Whatever may be said about sustainable travel, the development itself is clearly making substantial provision for car ownership and car use.

Those cars have to go somewhere.

People are going to work. They're taking children to school. They're going shopping. They're heading towards Rayleigh Weir, the A127, Southend and the surrounding road network.

And you just know what happens when the main roads are congested — people start looking for other ways through, and the pressure on the local rat-runs gets worse as well.

We already know what Rayleigh traffic is like during the morning and evening peaks. It can be chaotic now.

Now this is where I think some of the figures in the applicant's Transport Assessment really need questioning.

For the 94 houses, their own assessment predicts 75 additional vehicle movements in the morning peak hour and 54 in the evening peak hour.

But when they distribute those journeys around the road network, they say that only nine additional vehicles would use the Daws Heath Road/A127 junction during the morning peak.

Nine.

They also predict 39 additional vehicle movements through Rayleigh Weir in the morning peak and 32 in the evening.

Residents know how people actually travel around here, so I think we are entitled to ask:

Do those assumptions really reflect what is going to happen once potentially hundreds of cars associated with these homes are sitting on people's driveways?

And what happens when the Weir is backed up and drivers start looking for alternative routes?

Because this development isn't being dropped into an empty road network. It is being added to a road network that is already under enormous pressure at peak times.

So when this site is described as sustainable and the traffic impact as manageable, I think residents have every right to say:

Really? Does that actually match the Rayleigh we live in every day?



SLIDE 21 - CUMULATIVE IMPACT

SPEAKER SCRIPT

And Lower Wyburns isn't happening in isolation.

There are other major housing schemes either proposed or coming forward around Rayleigh as well.

Lower Wyburns — 94 homes.

Limehouse — 142 homes.

Napier and Wellington — 87 homes.

Great Wheatley — 152 homes.

That's around 475 additional homes altogether.

And when you start adding all of that together, the cumulative effect on our roads and local services could be absolutely diabolical.

And I need to take this opportunity to apologise to the Hambro Hill residents, because I know you've got an application going on as well and I completely overlooked it when I put this slide together.

By the time I realised, it was too late to change the slide, so I do apologise.

If anybody from Hambro Hill wants to shout out how many homes are potentially involved there, we can add those to our grand total as well.

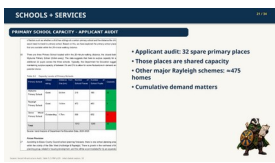
[PAUSE FOR RESPONSE]

And remember, these are just the developments and applications we know about and are talking about here. This doesn't include all the other proposals and potential sites being discussed through the wider planning process.

All those extra homes mean extra journeys, extra demand on schools and services, and extra pressure on infrastructure.

That is why I don't believe it is good enough to assess these developments as though each one exists in its own little bubble.

We need to look at the cumulative effect of everything being proposed for Rayleigh — because that is the reality residents are ultimately going to have to live with.



SLIDE 22 - SCHOOLS + SERVICES

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now let's look at schools and local services.

The applicant's own Social Infrastructure Audit says there are currently 32 spare primary-school places across the schools they looked at.

But those places are not sitting there waiting specifically for this development. They are shared capacity for the whole area.

And when you remember the other major developments we've just been talking about, that becomes very important.

A spare school place can only be used once.

So if you already live in this area, you've got young children, and you're thinking they may eventually go to Wyburns Primary School, additional development means additional competition for the places that are available.

Unfortunately, getting the local school place you were hoping for could become more difficult.

And when we get to secondary schools, the applicant's own figures are even more concerning, because they already show an overall shortage of secondary-school places across the schools they assessed.

And that is before we start adding together the cumulative effect of all these other developments.

So where are all these additional children supposed to go?

If hundreds of additional homes are being proposed across Rayleigh, all of those developments potentially create additional demand for the same schools and the same local services.

So again, we don't think it is good enough to look at Lower Wyburns on its own.

The real question is whether the schools, services and infrastructure can cope with the combined demand from all of the development being proposed around Rayleigh.



SLIDE 23 - FLOOD RISK + BROOK

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now we come to flood risk and Eastwood Brook.

As we said earlier, Eastwood Brook is officially classified by the Environment Agency as a Main River.

Parts of the northern area are also shown within Flood Zones 2 and 3.

The applicant is proposing a drainage system that would collect and temporarily store surface water from the development, slow it down, and ultimately discharge it towards Eastwood Brook through the existing drainage system.

That means we think the drainage proposals need to be looked at extremely carefully.

It isn't simply a question of whether water can be managed within the development boundary.

We also need to understand what happens downstream, what happens during extreme rainfall, and whether the proposals could affect people and land further along the Brook.

When you are building next to a Main River and close to areas already identified as being at flood risk, we think residents are entitled to expect those questions to be answered properly.



SLIDE 24 - WHAT SUDS DOES

SPEAKER SCRIPT

So what actually is SuDS?

It stands for Sustainable Drainage Systems, but in simple terms it is the system designed to deal with rainwater falling on the development.

Instead of allowing all that water to run off immediately, the system is supposed to collect it, temporarily store it and then release it more slowly.

The proposals here include things like swales, an attenuation basin and underground storage.

But the important point for us is where that water ultimately goes.

The applicant's drainage strategy proposes that surface water will eventually discharge through the existing drainage system towards Eastwood Brook.

So slowing the water down is important — but we also need confidence that the whole system will work properly during heavy and prolonged rainfall, and that it will not create additional problems further downstream.

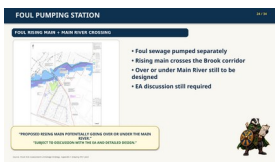
And there is another question that still needs answering.

Eastwood Brook has riparian owners — people whose properties adjoin the Brook and who may have legal rights and responsibilities connected with it.

Depending on exactly how and where the drainage connects or discharges, there may also be questions about whether the developer has the necessary rights or permissions from affected riparian owners.

So before anybody simply assumes that water from this development can be sent towards Eastwood Brook, we want to know what rights they actually have to do that, and whether any additional consents or agreements are required.

That needs to be established properly — not simply assumed.



SLIDE 25 - FOUL PUMPING STATION

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now this is separate from the surface-water drainage we've just talked about.

Foul sewage from the development would be pumped away from the site through a rising main.

And this is where it becomes particularly interesting.

The applicant's own drainage drawing shows that proposed rising main crossing the Eastwood Brook corridor.

On their own plan they actually say:

"Proposed rising main potentially going over or under the Main River."

And underneath that:

"Subject to discussion with the EA and detailed design."

In other words, at the time these documents were prepared, they had not yet finalised whether this sewage pipe would go over or underneath Eastwood Brook.

That seems to us to be a fairly important detail.

And there's another question. This is a pumping station. What happens if the power fails or the pumping equipment breaks down?

Sewage doesn't stop arriving just because the pump has stopped working.

So what emergency storage is provided? Is there backup power? What alarms and monitoring will there be? How long can the system cope if there is a failure?

And particularly importantly, who is ultimately going to own, operate and maintain it?

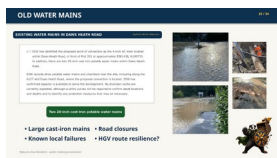
From the application information we've looked at, we have not found those emergency arrangements clearly set out.

And when this infrastructure is being proposed close to Eastwood Brook, we think those are extremely important questions. A failure involving foul sewage in this location could potentially have very serious environmental consequences.

We're talking about a Main River, a proposed foul-sewage rising main, and a crossing whose final design still requires discussion with the Environment Agency.

So again, we think residents are entitled to ask:

Shouldn't all of this be properly worked out before the development is approved?



SLIDE 26 - OLD WATER MAINS

SPEAKER SCRIPT

There is another infrastructure issue underneath Daws Heath Road that we think needs looking at.

The applicant's own Utilities Statement identifies two large 20-inch cast-iron water mains running along Daws Heath Road.

Local residents already know that there have been water-main failures and road closures in this area.

We are not saying that construction HGVs will definitely cause a water-main failure. But if this road is going to be used regularly by heavy construction traffic for around two years, we think it is perfectly reasonable to ask:

Has the condition and resilience of those old water mains been properly considered?

And if there is another failure while Daws Heath Road is also being used as a major construction route, what happens then?

There is another issue as well.

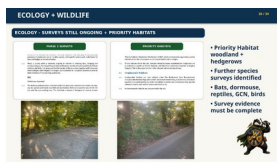
Parts of the subsoil beneath a highway can still be privately owned, even though the surface is used as a public road.

Now utility companies have statutory powers to carry out necessary repairs in highways, so we are not suggesting that a private landowner can automatically prevent emergency work.

But if heavy construction traffic causes or contributes to damage requiring excavation and major repair work, who takes responsibility for that damage, what rights are needed to carry out the works, and what disruption does that create for the people whose land and properties adjoin the road?

And most importantly, has anybody actually looked at this before deciding that Daws Heath Road is an appropriate route for sustained HGV traffic?

Again, this is why we believe the practical reality of this road needs much more careful consideration.



SLIDE 27 - ECOLOGY + WILDLIFE

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now we come to ecology and wildlife.

The applicant's own ecological work identifies priority habitat woodland and hedgerows around the site.

It also identifies the need for further survey work covering species including bats, dormice, reptiles, Great Crested Newts and birds.

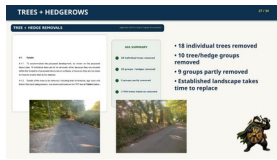
And local residents know this area supports a wide range of wildlife. We regularly see species here that depend upon the woodland, hedgerows, Brook and open countryside.

So our concern is very straightforward.

The ecological evidence needs to be complete before decisions are made that could permanently change or remove those habitats.

Once established habitat has been lost, you cannot simply recreate it overnight by putting a few new plants and trees somewhere else.

That is why we believe the full ecological picture needs to be properly understood before development takes place, not afterwards.



SLIDE 28 - TREES + HEDGEROWS

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now let's look at trees and hedgerows.

According to the applicant's own Arboricultural Impact Assessment, the proposals would involve the removal of 18 individual trees and 10 tree or hedge groups, with a further 9 groups partly removed.

These trees, hedgerows and established boundaries are part of the existing character of this area. They also provide habitat and wildlife corridors.

The developer can propose replacement planting, and of course new planting is better than nothing.

But a newly planted tree or hedge is not an immediate replacement for established vegetation that has taken decades to develop.

So when we assess the impact of this development, we think the loss and fragmentation of that established landscape needs to be taken seriously.

Once mature landscape features are removed, replacing their value takes time — in some cases, many years.



SLIDE 29 - HERITAGE BEFORE DAMAGE

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now, I could talk about this for hours — but I've been told I'm not allowed to!

So this is going to have to be a very brief summary.

What we have found is potentially extremely interesting.

We've identified a series of surviving earthworks and ponds in this landscape which we believe need proper archaeological investigation.

And we've now got an archaeologist coming down in the middle of September specifically to look at the principal surviving earthworks we've found.

What makes this particularly interesting is that there is historic documentary evidence for ponds and water-management features in this wider landscape.

We have a document dating from 1431 which refers to fish ponds and a "stank" belonging to Philippa, Duchess of York.

A stank is an old term associated with holding or impounding water, often involving a substantial bank.

And what we are finding on the ground appears to form part of a wider landscape running along Eastwood Brook and down into the Rayleigh valley, in the vicinity of Lower Wyburns.

Some of these features could potentially have medieval origins, but that is exactly what now needs specialist investigation. We shouldn't pretend we've proved their date or purpose before the archaeological work has been done.

And there's another possibility which makes this even more interesting.

We may also have identified the site of a long-lost watermill.

Historic research into the Rayleigh area refers to a watermill whose location has been lost for centuries, and some of the landscape evidence we are now finding around Eastwood Brook raises the possibility that this could be connected with it.

Again, I want to be very clear: we haven't proved that yet.

But when you put together the surviving earthworks, the ponds, the Brook, the historic documentary evidence and the possibility of a lost watermill site, there is surely enough here to say:

Stop. Investigate it properly before anything is destroyed.

And other people are taking it seriously as well. Thundersley Historic Group and Rayleigh Town Museum are interested, and we're now seeing people from the different communities and settlements coming together to research this landscape and work out exactly what we've discovered.

Because if these features do turn out to be historically significant, and if we really have rediscovered part of Rayleigh's lost medieval landscape, once it is destroyed, we can never get that evidence back.



SLIDE 30 - WHAT WE ASK THE COUNCIL

SPEAKER SCRIPT

So after everything we've looked at tonight, what are we actually asking the Council to do?

We're asking them to pause and reassess this area properly.

We want the Green Belt assessment to properly address Eastwood Brook and the real physical boundaries on the ground.

We want the land divided into fair and logical parcels, so that genuinely different areas aren't simply lumped together.

And we want the historic and archaeological evidence properly considered, particularly in light of what is now being discovered.

We're not asking for the impossible.

We're simply saying:

Why not get this right before the Local Plan is submitted?

Because surely it is better to correct these problems now, rather than wait until they have to be argued about later.



SLIDE 31 - HOW TO OBJECT

SPEAKER SCRIPT

Now we come to what residents can actually do.

If you want to object to the Bellway development, it is important that your objection is based on planning reasons.

Make sure you quote the correct application number:

26/00538/FUL.

You don't need to write pages and pages. Make the points that concern you, explain why they concern you, and if you have your own local knowledge or evidence, include it.

Most importantly, keep it factual and put it in your own words.

On the next two slides, we've set out six of the main objection grounds that residents may want to consider.



SLIDE 32 - OBJECTION GROUNDS 1-3

SPEAKER SCRIPT

The first three broad reasons you may want to use are Green Belt, road safety and construction lorries, and flooding and drainage. You do not have to use all three. Choose the things that genuinely concern you. For example, if you regularly walk Daws Heath Road, explain what the road is like. If you have seen flooding, say where and when. Personal experience is most useful when it supports a genuine planning concern.



SLIDE 33 - OBJECTION GROUNDS 4–6

SPEAKER SCRIPT

The other three headings are wildlife and landscape, history and archaeology, and sustainability and infrastructure. Those are planning labels, but the ideas are ordinary: what happens to wildlife and the countryside, what historic features could be lost, and whether the roads, drainage, sewage system and local services can really support the scheme. Use the points that matter to you rather than trying to include everything.



SLIDE 34 - COUNCILLOR EMAIL

SPEAKER SCRIPT

The councillor email is about the Green Belt assessment, not the Bellway planning objection. It can be very short. Say you support the Wyburns Area Residents concerns, ask for RA50 and RA51 to be reassessed, and ask councillors to raise it at the next committee. When the slide says 'do not wait for Inspector', it simply means this: if the evidence is available now, why leave the argument until the later Planning Inspector examination instead of looking at it properly now?



SLIDE 35 - STANDING TOGETHER

SPEAKER SCRIPT

That brings us back to the simple message we started with. This is about our countryside, our Green Belt, our community and its future. We are not asking people to accept everything we say without question. We are asking residents to look at the evidence, make up their own minds, and if they share these concerns, make their own planning objection and contact their councillors. Thank you for listening, and we will help anybody who wants assistance with the next steps.